

Seats Where the Seats Already Are

A walking-network coverage analysis of public seating, against a ward-level provision count

Ronja Oyelaran · Petra Umbile · Torun Ezeigwe — School of Emergent Priorities

Motivation

Provision counts report seats per 1,000 residents, ward by ward. Nobody walks a ward. A resident walks a route and rests wherever a seat happens to fall. Does a ward that provides well also cover the walk?

Research questions

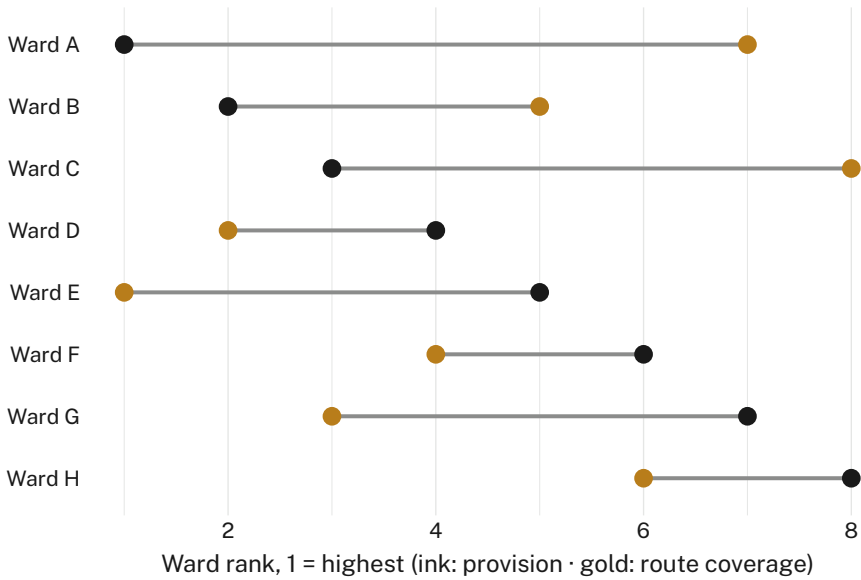
- What share of the walked network lies within 200 m of a public seat?
- How long is the longest seatless run on the routes residents take?
- Does rank on provision track rank on route coverage?

Study design

- 8 wards · 1,206 seats surveyed on foot · 96 audited routes · 14 weeks
- Routes traced from resident-nominated errands (shops, clinic, bus stop) and measured with a wheel; seat positions surveyed, not read off the asset register
- Coverage computed along the walkable network, never a straight-line radius; the 200 m rest interval fixed before fieldwork and not adjusted

What we found

41.3% of the walked network sits within 200 m of a public seat, and the median longest seatless run on an audited route is 780 m. Provision rank appears largely unrelated to coverage rank: 63% of seats installed in the past four years landed on segments already within 200 m of a seat.



Each ward’s rank on the council’s provision count — seats per 1,000 residents (ink) — against its rank on the share of walked network within 200 m of a seat (gold). Three of the four wards ranked highest on provision sit in the bottom half on coverage: Ward A ranks 1st and 7th, Ward C 3rd and last. The two wards that cover their routes best, E and D, rank 5th and 4th on the count that funds them.

Implications & where next

A count of assets per resident can rise while the walk it stands for does not improve. The register records where a seat is easiest to install; the route records where one is missing, and on present evidence the two agree only in the wards already ranked low on provision. Coverage is a property of the network between the seats, which no per-resident denominator can hold. Installation history suggests why: a segment that already has a seat is the cheapest place to put the next one, and the count rewards the purchase either way. Nothing here recommends fewer seats. The claim is narrower — that a ward can lead its region on provision and still leave its longest walks unbroken, and that no denominator per resident will show it. Next: the seat-gap segments are tabled to the Indicator Commons as a supplementary series, reported alongside the provision count rather than in place of it; a second season extends the audit to the routes residents abandoned before the survey opened.

Selected references

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We thank the residents who nominated the audited routes, and the crews who walked them.

Audits were conducted on public footpaths; no resident was accompanied or recorded. Ward identifiers de-identified at the council’s request. The rest interval and the route-selection rule were lodged with the School before fieldwork.

Contact: ronja.oyelaran@slop.university · Office of Research Outputs

@slop.university · #slopU